Interviewer guide: Years 11 and 12

This guide is reusable. Nothing is written on it: keep one in the room, in a folder or laminated. Ratings and notes for each student go on the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y11_Y12`).

About 15 minutes, 1:1. The interview is held **in English**. It has three jobs: to hear the student's spoken English (the speaking band), to get to know the student (interests, learning, wellbeing, **future plans and aspirations**), and to judge their **suitability** for the international programme at post-16 (Year 11 joins the second year of IGCSE; Year 12 joins the first year of A Level). It opens with the Graded Sentence Reading Screen (3 to 5 minutes; start Level 9 for both Year 11 and Year 12; follow `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide` and write the points on the Reading front sheet, `forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`).

How to ask. Start with the main question. If the student struggles, use the **easier** prompt (a yes or no, or a choice). If they answer easily, use the **stretch** prompt. This lets every student show their best English. Wait at least five seconds before rephrasing. Answers must be in English.

Pace of speech. Speak at a steady, clear pace, with a short pause after each sentence. Use the same pace for every candidate in the year group, and use it for the instructions and meaning questions of the sentence reading too. Do not rush: wait at least five seconds before rephrasing.

Safeguarding. Keep the door open or another adult present. If a student tells you something that worries you about their safety or wellbeing, do not promise to keep it secret; listen, write down their words, and pass it to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.

1. Questions (10 minutes)

Choose about two questions from each block. On the Interview sheet, write short notes under "Key things the student said": what they said, and how they said it.

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
Warm-up	Tell me a little about yourself.	What is your name? How old are you? Where do you live?	What would your friends say about you?
School and learning	Tell me about your school now. Which subject do you find hardest, and what do you do when work is difficult?	Do you like your school? Is maths easy or hard for you?	Tell me about a time you kept going when something was hard. What is the biggest difference you expect between your school and ours?
Subject choices	Which IGCSE or A Level subjects would you like to take, and why? Who chose them: you, your parents, or both together?	Which subjects do you like best? Was it your idea?	How do they connect to what you want to study later?
	What do you know about the courses: the topics, the exams, any coursework?	Do you know what an IGCSE or an A Level is?	How is this course different from what you study now?
	What will you do if a subject is harder than you expected?	Would you ask a teacher for help?	How would you decide whether to keep going or to change subject?
Study and workload	How do you revise for a test? Tell me what you actually do.	Do you make notes? Do you practise questions?	Which methods work best for you, and how do you know?
	How many hours a week do you study outside lessons? Do you have tutoring?	Do you study at the weekend?	How do you feel about how busy you are?
	How do you manage deadlines when several subjects set work at the same time?	Do you use a planner or a list?	Tell me about a time you had too much to do. What did you do?
English for study	How do you feel about reading long texts in English, such as a textbook chapter or a novel?	Do you read in English? What do you read?	What do you do when a text has many words you do not know?

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
	Have you written an essay in English? Tell me about it.	Can you write a paragraph in English?	What is hardest about writing in English: the ideas, the organisation or the language?
	How do you feel about speaking in class, asking questions and giving your opinion in English?	Will you put your hand up in a lesson?	What would help you to speak more in lessons?
University plans	What would you like to do after school? Which countries or universities are you thinking about, and why?	Do you want to go to university? In China or another country?	Why does that place interest you? What might be difficult about studying there?
	What do you know about what those universities ask for: grades, subjects, English tests, interviews?	Do you know which grades you would need?	What have you found out yourself, and where did you look?
Interests and service	What do you enjoy outside school? Have you taken part in service, volunteering, competitions or a leadership role?	Do you like sport, music or art? Do you help at home or in your community?	What have you achieved that you are proud of, and what did you learn from it?
Friends and wellbeing	Who do you spend time with at school? How do you relax when you feel tired or stressed?	Do you have good friends? What makes you happy?	How do you balance study, activities, sleep and rest?
Boarding (only if the student will board)	Have you lived away from home before? How do you manage your own routines: sleep, getting up on time, washing clothes?	Have you stayed away from home for a week or more? Do you get yourself up in the morning?	What will be hardest about boarding, and how would you deal with feeling homesick?
Values	A friend asks you to send them your essay so they can hand it in as their own. What do you do?	Is it OK to copy work?	Why does honesty matter in learning?
Year 11 only	You would join the second year of a two-year IGCSE course. What does that mean for you, and how would you catch up?	Do you know that the other students started the course a year ago? Would you ask for extra lessons?	In which subjects do you expect the biggest gap, and how would you close it?
Questions for us	What would you like to ask me about the school or the courses?	Do you have any questions?	

2. Speaking band

Choose the band that fits best, using the evidence from the whole interview, and tick it on the Interview sheet. Rate **listening in conversation** (how much of your English they understood) with the same letters. Pronunciation features of a speaker of Chinese do not lower the band if the student is easy to understand.

Band	What you hear
A New to English	Little or no spoken English, or single memorised words and phrases ("I am fine"). Relies on Chinese, gesture or silence. Understands very little unless supported.
B Early acquisition	Short answers and simple memorised sentences on familiar topics (family, school, likes). Frequent errors in word order, verbs and plurals. Needs the easier prompts. Understands slow, simple questions.
C Developing competence	Answers most main questions with connected sentences, using "because", "but", "so". Errors are frequent but meaning is usually clear. Vocabulary is everyday; searches for words on less familiar topics. Can give a short opinion with a reason.
D Competent	Speaks at length on most questions, explains and gives examples, handles the stretch prompts with some effort. Errors are occasional and rarely affect meaning. Some subject and abstract vocabulary.
E Fluent	Speaks as fluently and accurately as a fluent English speaker of the same age. Handles abstract and hypothetical questions easily, with a wide vocabulary.

3. Suitability

Rate each strand on the Interview sheet from what you saw and heard: **1** Concern, **2** Some concern, **3** Good, **4** Strong. Write the evidence: a short quotation or something you observed.

Strand	What strong looks like
Attitude to learning and resilience	Wants to learn, has a go, keeps going when work is hard, talks about effort and improvement
Curiosity and engagement	Asks questions, shows interest in ideas beyond the textbook, enjoys discussion
Social and emotional readiness	Relaxed or able to settle, makes eye contact (allowing for culture and shyness), talks about friends, manages feelings, ready for a change of school
Independence and self-management	Organises themselves, can describe how they study, manages time and activities, will ask for help
Values and conduct	Kind, honest and respectful in the interview and in the values question
Readiness for English-medium learning	Motivated to learn in English, willing to speak even with mistakes, has strategies for new words
Clarity and ownership of future plans	Has thought about what comes next, the plans are their own as well as the family's, understands why the international programme fits
Independent study and readiness for post-16 work	Can describe how they study on their own, realistic about the workload, has read about the courses

Boarding readiness (only if the student will board): independence with daily routines, sleep, homesickness, experience of being away from home. Rate it on the Interview sheet in the same way.

4. Anything to follow up

Tick any that apply on the Interview sheet, and add a note:

- Possible special educational need or disability (for example reading, attention, speech, hearing, vision)
- Wellbeing (for example anxiety, low mood, very heavy workload, sleep)
- Safeguarding (passed to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day)
- Medical or dietary
- Mismatch between the student's wishes and the family's plans

Receiving homeroom teacher (optional). If the student's likely homeroom teacher meets them, they note first impressions and what the student would need in the first weeks (for example a buddy who speaks Chinese, a vocabulary book for each subject, a quiet check-in each morning) on the Interview sheet.

To finish. On the Interview sheet, write your comment for the final mark sheet (strengths, concerns, support), and sign and date it.